

Ink, Blood & *Other Afflictions*

Episode Three



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Other Afflictions
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Kristen Coar

OceanofPDF.com

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Stay Tuned

Acknowledgments

Note from the author

About the author

To the ghosts we kissed, the wounds we named, and the monsters we let stay. When healing isn't gentle. When it's bloody, brutal, and sometimes... worth it.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Goddess

HE WAS IN THE trees.
I could smell him.

The forest was wet with shadow, the ground lush beneath my bare feet, loam and moss and old rot wafting up through the air like perfume. Somewhere in the distance, a wolf howled, too loud to be him. He was cleverer than that. Always cleverer.

I smiled.

My hair fell loose around me, damp and heavy with mist, raven-black to my waist. He liked it that way—wild, undone. I liked it better twisted in his fists.

The wind shifted.

Cedar. Sweat. Smoke.

There.

I moved.

Not running. Not yet. Let the hunt have tension. Let him feel me coming. Feel my presence moving through his dream like blood through veins. He'd carved this place from memory and will, seeded the ground with every scent and sound he thought might please me. Even my body—this shape I wore—was his doing. The curve of my hips. The taste of my mouth. All conjured. All gifted. All his.

But the hunger?

That was mine.

A flash between trees—his shoulder, bare and marked with old ink, vanishing before I could snatch him. Tease.

I gave chase.

Branches clawed at me, gentle as lovers. My legs were long, sure, made for speed. I wove through undergrowth, laughter caught behind my teeth. He made me learn joy, this man. It wasn't warm or tender. No. This was joy. The thrill of the chase, the violence of want.

I would catch him. I always did. And depending on how long he made me work for it, he'd find himself rewarded accordingly.

A rustle to the right.

I adjusted course, soundless as death.

He liked it when I hunted him like this—when I let the old part of myself rise up and wrap around the new. He called it play, but it was worship. Every footstep I took was a hymn. Every breath, a spell.

He wasn't far now. I could taste him on the wind. The salt of him. The excitement.

I broke into a run, the ground falling away beneath me, breath harsh in my lungs.

He would not escape me.

He never did.



CHAPTER TWO

Him

MERCER DIDN'T LOOK UP as I stepped under the tape.
“Your girl know you're here?”

It was meant to dig, but I let it sit.

The alley stank of old piss, burnt grease, and a sour trace of rot underneath, but it was the blood that caught my attention. Fresh, copper-bright, and still tacky beneath the floodlights. The body lay beyond, framed like a performance piece under the buzz of power lines.

“It's getting worse,” I said, stepping around a cone. The forensic markers were scattered like breadcrumbs, but they wouldn't lead anywhere useful. These weren't messy, thoughtless kills. They only looked reckless. In truth, they were meticulous, leaving nothing behind.

No DNA. No prints. No drag marks. No hesitation wounds.

“She was posed.” Mercer was beside me. “Like the others. But this one's louder.” He shook his head. “Never seen anything like it.”

The body hung from rusted rebar—ribs cracked open and bent back one by one, splintered ends jutting like jagged branches. Her lungs had been pulled through the opening and draped over the bones, slick and pink against the red. Each was placed with deliberate care, symmetrical, almost delicate, as if the killer wanted to build something from her.

“It’s called a blood eagle,” I said. “Popularized in the ninth century. Viking execution. Reserved for betrayal.”

“What the fuck kind of shit are you and your girl involved in?” The police lieutenant turned to me, eyes narrowed. “Have you seen something like this before?”

My mind flickered—just once—to a monastery outside Uppsala. It was the winter of 1291. Snow as deep as a man’s chest, and the sound a spine makes when it’s pulled from a body.

“BBC did a documentary a couple years back,” I said flatly. “I like history. Just so happens most of it’s bloody.”

Mercer grunted. “You got a point.” He stepped closer, the gravel crunching under his boots. “It’s like he’s laughing at us. Whoever’s doing this.” He gestured to the wall behind the corpse. “Who the hell takes time to paint a mural after carving someone open?”

“A psycho,” I answered, leaning closer.

Painted across the brick in long, arcing strokes was a set of bright, stylized wings rendered in the victim’s blood. The strokes were clean. Measured. The final bow.

I exhaled. If only it were simply a human psychopath, and not a spirit with a flair for spectacle and a long-standing obsession. One who’d been chasing shadows across centuries. One who’d finally found her again—his wife, or the closest thing he could get. And she just happened to be wrapped in the skin of the very mortal woman I couldn’t let go.

My jaw flexed.

“Yeah,” Mercer muttered, pulling a cigarette from his coat. “Absolute psycho.”

He lit it, shielding the flame with one hand.

“This makes three new ones.” The end flared red in the dark. “All in the last month.”

I studied the woman’s face. Early thirties. Blood clinging to the blonde roots like a crown. Another version of Vera, but Mercer didn’t need to say it. We both felt the echo.

“David Manning is dead,” he said after a beat. “So why the hell is someone still playing with entrails? And why do they all look like your girl?”

I didn’t answer right away. He wouldn’t like it.

Mercer flicked ash to the ground, watching it dissolve in a puddle near the curb. “You said you didn’t think it was over with David. That someone else was pulling strings. That we’d see more of the same.”

I crossed my arms, the leather of my jacket creaking faintly in the cold. “You didn’t seem inclined to believe me that night.”

“You’d just killed the guy. It should’ve been over.” He jerked his chin toward the body. “The first one—other side of the city—maybe that was coincidence. Even the second could have just been typical Chicago. But now this? Back in your girl’s neighborhood?” He looked at me hard. “It’s too much to chalk up as random.”

My lips pressed tight. “Took three dead women for that to land?”

“Fuck you.” Wind knifed between the buildings, stirring the blood-heavy air. “There was clearly more going on at the candy factory, and neither of you gave me even a piece of it.”

“Comforting logic,” I said dryly.

“Every day you withhold something is another day this freak stays loose.” Mercer stepped in close. “And Vera’s not just some unlucky target.”

I didn’t move. “You think she brought this on herself?”

“What?” His tone shifted. “No. Of course not. There’s no excuse for whatever the shit this is.”

Mercer exhaled hard and dragged a hand down his face, then pinched the bridge of his nose. “But you both know more than you’re saying. And keeping me in the dark makes it easier for him to get her. You might not give a shit about the others, but you care about her.”

I didn’t speak. Nothing I said would make sense to him, and anything that did would put Vera on his radar as more than just a stubborn victim.

“Fine.” Mercer stepped back. “You don’t want to loop me in.”

“You know everything I know.” I lied.

“Right.” Mercer snorted. “Well, just tell me you’re getting her the hell out of town.”

I raked a hand back through my hair, cold fingers threading tight at the scalp. “Yes. This weekend.”

“Someplace warm, I hope.” He pulled his coat tighter, his breath fogging between us. The chill was sinking in teeth first this year. Then he paused. “Why not sooner? I’m sure the library can find someone to babysit the Dewey Decimal System. The books aren’t going anywhere.”

I huffed a deep laugh. “Don’t let her hear you say that.”

“Yeah, yeah.” He waved it off. “But seriously, man. Why wait? You’ve got the cash. Take her away until we catch this guy.”

“I would’ve whisked her out of the city three weeks ago if she’d let me.”

Mercer shook his head and started walking, leading us out of the alley. “Bit off more than you could chew with that one.”

“You’re not wrong.” I smiled faintly. “But she’s got this thing Friday night. The library’s annual fundraiser. She’s running point this year, and the only way I’m getting her to skip it is to—her words—kill her, and even then, she’d make sure I bled out trying. Said by the time it was over, we’d both be dead and the library would need a hazmat crew.”

Mercer stopped short. “Jesus Christ,” he said, rubbing his jaw. “She say it like that?”

I looked at him. “More detail. More swearing.”

Mercer stopped short. Then barked out a laugh loud enough to make one of the techs flinch.

“Lieutenant?” A younger CSU analyst looked up from where she was crouched near the wall, measuring spatter angles.

“Nothing, Tara.” He wiped his eyes. “Just—nothing.”

Turning back to me, a line creased deep at his brow. “A joke like that when she’s got a real psycho after her?”

“Yes.” My mouth curved, then dipped. “It’s the first time she’s sounded like herself since the candy factory.”

Mercer stopped walking, and for once, he didn’t try to fill the silence.

Then, softer, “I’m sorry.”

I looked at him.

He shrugged, the stiffness in his shoulders betraying more than his tone. “I mean it. That kind of trauma... I’ve seen too many officers burn out from less. We’ve come a long way since I started—back when Jim Beam was the only therapist on the payroll.” He gave a humorless smile. “If she ever wants resources, I’ve got them. Not just CPD. Real help. You don’t have to do this alone.”

“Thank you, Lieutenant,” I said. “When she’s ready, I’ll try. And until then, I’ll do what I can to help her find her way back.”

“And you?” Mercer asked, flicking a glance my way. “Getting kidnapped and almost dying, followed by killing a man, is no small thing.

“A drop in the bucket.” I shrugged.

“Sure.” He opened his mouth like he wanted to argue, then shut it again. “Not my business.”

The alley had hushed behind us with only the murmur of forensics doing cleanup and the occasional camera shutter. Blood had stopped steaming in the cold, but the body was still nailed open like a warning no one here could read.

Mercer adjusted his coat. “With any luck, I don’t see you again until Friday.”

I raised an eyebrow. “What’s Friday?”

“The damn Halloween Gala. Wife’s Christmas present from last year.” He exhaled through his nose. “I’d hoped she’d forget. No such luck. The bird’s been planning her dress for six months. Now she’s making me put on a tie.”

“Sounds brutal.”

“It is. But it’s cheaper than diamonds.” He paused. “Though not by much.”

I held out a hand. “Thanks for the heads-up tonight.”

He clasped it briefly. “Just keep that woman safe.”

“I will.”

He didn’t say goodbye when he turned and walked back toward the floodlights, shoulders hunched, muttering something under his breath about sequins and open bars.

I waited until he was out of sight before pulling out my phone. One tap pulled up the security grid—motion sensors, external cams, and a line of sight on every entrance and window Vera refused to lock properly. Her apartment. Her car. The library. Even the sidewalk across the street.

My pulse didn’t ease until I saw her—blonde hair pulled back, standing just inside the library’s front doors, her finger tapping against a clipboard while she talked to Margaret.

She was safe for now.

Sliding my phone back into my coat, I stepped off the curb. Pavement grit whispered beneath the soles of my shoes as I crossed to the car—black paint dulled by alley dust, the handle cold against my fingers.

Vera hadn’t hunted since the candy factory, or even touched her knife. Instead, she had retreated from the part of herself that survived, that *thrived*, when things got dangerous.

She said she was fine, but I saw the lie.

So I had made a plan. It would hurt. But it would *snap her back into herself* before the fear finished what that bastard started. I hoped.

Because she needed to remember what she was if she wanted to survive whatever that warped spirit inside her had planned.

And I'd make damn sure she did—whether she wanted to or not.

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CHAPTER THREE

Her

“YOU’LL NEED TO KEEP the lilies along the far wall.” I gestured toward the north-facing windows. “Right there. On either side of the Card Catalog display. We get afternoon light through that glass, and the petals will catch it. Real dramatic.”

The florist—Beth, I think her name was—nodded, scribbling something on her clipboard. She wore an oversized scarf and a hopeful expression. The Halloween Gala was probably the biggest event she’d do all year.

“Calla lilies for the bones,” I continued, pointing to the lower credenza near the rare books case. “Dark red ranunculus for the blood. A bit of black lace fern to give it shadow. And we’ll drape ivy—real, not that plastic shit—over the railing on the mezzanine. Let it hang. Gothic, not garden party.”

“That’s intense.” Beth gave a whistle. “I love it!”

“It’s Gothic Romance.” I shrugged. “It’s supposed to be.”

We moved down the main aisle, her sneakers squeaking against the polished floor, each step a small, grating sound that scraped behind my eyes.

“Over here.” I stepped between the reading chairs. “We’ll use darker tones. Burgundy dahlias. Plum callas. Maybe some of that deep wine-colored scabiosa—like dried blood, but prettier.”

“Perfect.” Beth hesitated, then offered a cautious smile. “And for the main arrangement on the circulation desk?”

“Something theatrical.” My fingers twitched toward the air like I could pluck the vision from it. “Roses, obviously. Black or near enough. Peonies, if you can find ones that haven’t bloomed yet—tight heads. No baby’s breath. This isn’t a prom.”

She nodded quickly, scribbling. “Got it. Bleeding beauty, decaying elegance, a touch of dread.”

I flinched, blinking hard. The words hit wrong—*bleeding beauty*—and suddenly it wasn’t flowers I saw, but my own blood slicking my fingers as they clawed at my chest.

“I didn’t mean.” She adjusted her scarf, looking down. “That was supposed to be a compliment.”

“It’s fine.” I sucked in a breath. “You’re exactly right.”

Every detail mattered. Every placement, every petal, every column of the Excel doc I’d built to track vendors. Everything had to be perfect. My hand trembled as I reached for the printout in my bag.

“You okay?” Beth asked.

“Just cold,” I said. “The HVAC in this building’s a bitch. Doesn’t switch over to heat until December.”

That was when Margaret stepped into view, a stack of donation forms in her arms and that warm, grandmotherly smile I used to find comforting.

Now it just made my skin crawl.

“Oh good,” she said. “I was hoping to catch you both. What if we used some of the old iron candelabras from the Founders’ display in the main setup? It might give a nice cathedral effect.”

I paused. Long enough that it became awkward.

“That’s...not quite the vibe,” I said tightly.

“Of course. Just a thought.” She turned to Beth with a smile. “You’re in good hands. We’re very lucky Vera volunteered to take the lead on this year’s Gala.”

Beth gave a half-laugh and glanced at me. I wasn’t smiling.

Internally, I reached for the Goddess. *Anything to say about that? No sly comment about me being born for drama or having a real talent for making corpses part of the aesthetic.*

Just silence.

Not even a hum of power.

That, more than anything, made my stomach turn.

Since the candy factory, she'd gone mostly quiet. No whispers. No dark mirth. No inappropriate comments at the sight of Nikolai in a towel. Just... absence.

I wasn't sure which scared me more—her silence, or how much I missed the sound of her voice in my head.

Ten more minutes of decorations planning, then I saw Beth to the door, walking her past the display cases and the front desk.

"This Gala's going to be stunning." Her eyes lit up as the door slid open, voice picking up speed as she rattled off centerpiece ideas and flower substitutions like she was already halfway to the wholesaler. "You've got the perfect vibe for it. Dark, elegant, dangerous..."

I gave a half-smile.

"So—do you know what you're wearing yet?" She took a breath to look at me.

"Ummm." Right. A dress. That's something people think about for events like this. I opened my mouth and closed it again. "Not yet."

"Well." Beth stepped outside, tugging her scarf tighter against the wind. "I'm sure whatever you wear will look fantastic."

I gave her a noncommittal nod. "We'll see."

Pausing at the top of the step, she grinned back at me. "See you in two days. I'll have everything I need by then." Then she turned to her car, waving behind her. "Can't wait!"

The moment she was gone, I leaned against the wood and exhaled. Not a sigh. A collapse.

A dress hadn't even crossed my mind. And truthfully? I wasn't sure I even wanted to go.

Nikolai had been pushing me to leave. Not hard or loud—just that low, constant pressure he was so good at. He wanted me out of the city and away from the danger. We both knew the thing inside David wasn't done with me.

But I'd insisted on staying—at least until after the Gala. I told Margaret it would be perfect. Swore I could handle it.

But maybe Nikolai was right. Maybe we should leave sooner.

I was exhausted from pretending. From smiling. From holding myself together with duct tape, caffeine, and color-coded lists when the only thing I felt was the static buzzing behind my eyes.

I'd finish the prep, hand Margaret the checklist, and walk out. He would take me away from here, and someone else could hold the weight for a while. I could do that, couldn't I?

"Everything's looking beautiful," Margaret said gently. "The flowers, the colors—it's exactly what the theme needed."

I didn't turn. "Thanks."

She lingered for a second, then stepped away, back toward the front desk. I heard the easy shuffle of papers, then the wheeze of the office chair as she lowered herself into it.

She's a good woman. The voice slithered through the back of my mind. *She does not deserve your venom.*

My hand drifted to my chest before I could stop it, fingers brushing the spot just below my sternum. The scar there still pulsed some nights, faint and aching.

"The spirit who hurt me—the one who hunted me—is still out there." My voice cracked as I pressed my palm hard into my chest, trying to calm the burn still buried deep beneath my skin. "And you fucking disappear."

Oh, my little monster. Her voice slipped through me like smoke, thinner than I'd ever heard it.

She sounded tired, but I didn't care.

"You've said nothing about the asshole who set up shop in David, or why he tried to rip my heart out. Or why he called you his wife."

Only silence answered my tirade, empty as the space between heartbeats when you're waiting to die.

Hello?! My fingers clenched at my sides as a gust of cold air filtered through the library's front doors.

A teenager stepped in, hood up, earbuds in, glittering backpack slung over one shoulder. I nodded toward her on instinct.

"YA fantasy's on the far wall," I called, throat dry.

She gave a thumbs-up, moving past me without a second look.

As the door latched behind her, I sagged against the nearest shelf. My fingers brushed the spine of a hardbound gothic anthology—cool leather under my hand. It took all my focus not to start ripping books off the shelves just to hear them hit the floor.

I am not his wife. The Goddess's voice finally cracked through my mind. *I was never his wife.*

Overhead, the lights droned, and something locked inside me, bracing for whatever came next.

Then why did he say that? I shot back. *And where the hell have you been the last three weeks?*

A pause.

Quelling the rune took more than I thought it would. Almost too much. She paused again. Pulling the pieces of myself back together... It was more challenging than expected.

I could almost feel the rune there, how it had burrowed before Nikolai tore it out with blood-soaked hands.

“Shit.” I exhaled, knees buckling at the memory. Stone teeth eating me alive, devouring my soul inch by inch. I had been dying. And when the cool stillness finally washed through me, I had thought it was her offering me peace before the end.

But she hadn’t been saying goodbye. She’d been saving me at great cost to herself.

“I’m sorry.” The realization landed hard, hollowing out the space deep in my lungs. “I didn’t know. I thought you’d abandoned me. Because I was weak. Because I needed to be rescued.”

I’d never said those words before. Not out loud, or even to myself. But they were true. I had never considered that she might be hurting, too. She’d retreated to heal.

Protecting me.

If I had known you’d sunk so far into self-pity without me, she drawled, I might’ve stayed gone longer. Really let you stew in it. Maybe develop a tragic drinking habit. Or find a tower to scream from.

I snorted and a paperback slipped from the shelf beside me, thudding against the carpet. I stared at it a second, nausea tunneling into my gut.

She wasn’t wrong.

I’d been wallowing, holding my fear like a shield and pretending it was armor.

A small smile tugged at my mouth before I could stop it. The dark goddess cared about me.

“So what’s with him, anyway?” I asked, voice still rough. “David was just a meat suit, right? So what the hell was inside him?”

Must we, really?

Somewhere deeper in the stacks, Margaret coughed and resumed tapping—fingers steady against the old tablet.

“Yes.” I bent to pick up the book I’d knocked loose. It was a well-worn copy of *The Princess Bride*, its spine creased, a corner dog-eared.

As you wish.

She sighed, as if exhausted by the need to explain herself, then began anyway.

He and I were born outside your concept of time. There was no form. No name. Just us, moving through a place with no edges—only darkness. I was cold. Still. Quiet. He was sound. Violence. Thunder without storm. We spun through that void for longer than your stars have burned. Nothing but each other.

“Sounds dramatic. And then?”

A crack of light. A breach.

My skin prickled, and a shiver ran down my back that had nothing to do with the library’s faulty climate control.

A voice came through. Singing. It was beautiful, strange, fragile. I reached for it.

She paused.

The other, he tried to hold me back. Raged at my absence. But I slipped through into the light.

“You left him,” I murmured. “That’s why he hates you.”

No. She sounded sad. We didn’t know what hate was. Not until we came here.

“Then what happened?”

The voice in the light belonged to a man, she said, and something shifted in her tone—more shape than sound.

She wasn’t just speaking now. She was there. Her presence twining along my spine in something almost...wistful.

Before him, I had moved through the void as thought, as hunger, as presence. I had no shape, no name. I was the concept that lingered at the edge of existence—the whisper before language. But he looked at me, and in that moment, I became.

Her voice thinned—no less strong, but more intimate.

His eyes were the color of the abyss, yet alive. Vast. And his grin was sunlight through smoke. He had ink on his fingers and laughter in his mouth, but when he sang, even the storm bent to listen.

I could almost hear the smooth tenor ringing in the space around me.

That was when it began. Not love, not yet. But the gravity of becoming. Of being seen. And I knew—whatever came next, I would never return to the void as I was.

“And the other followed,” I said, caught in her memory.

He couldn’t bear to be without me. Couldn’t stand to be alone.

My phone buzzed—Nikolai. I glanced at it, just his name and a one-line check-in:

Have you eaten today?

I flipped it over.

Where there had once been two, there were suddenly three, the Goddess continued. I lived in the man’s heart. My twin, on his shoulder.

She sounded...sad.

With us, he became more than a simple man. He was worshipped, and so Hunin and I were worshipped through him. Symbols they didn’t understand but feared anyway.

I let out a dry laugh. “Hunin? Like the raven?”

The Goddess hummed in the back of my mind.

“I suppose that makes you Munin?” I asked.

That’s how my mortal heard it, she replied with a note of something close to affection. The closest word his clumsy tongue could manage. Munin. Muu-neen. Memory made flesh. Or something like it. The sound pleased him.

I coughed, rolling my eyes. “Let me guess. Your sorcerer, all runes and riddles—his name was Odin. The one-eyed war daddy, Allfather himself.”

So you did read the Edda. I was beginning to think you ignored all my recommendations.

“It was a slow day.” I crossed back behind the circulation desk and dropped into my chair, the old cushion wheezing under my weight. A stack of name tags waited for me to alphabetize them, but my hands hovered over the Sharpie.

“So what happened?” I asked. “The three of you. Bad breakup?”

Leave it to you to take an event of cosmological significance and reduce it to such mundane trappings.

“Am I wrong?”

No, my little monster, you are not.

The words lingered.

“So what happened?”

What always happens when you mix men, power, and love. Corruption. Betrayal. And eventually ruin. It is their way. They burn bright, but never long.

I stilled, trailing my fingers along the rough edge of the desk.

There was more. I could feel it in the way her presence cooled—not withdrawn, but wary. Like there were wounds in that memory she didn’t want to look at or show me.

“Hunin wants you back, then?” I asked. “I assume Odin isn’t running around Chicago.”

He wants to return to the void, but he doesn’t want to go alone.

“And you don’t want to leave?”

No. She was silent a moment longer, then added, I am no longer what I was. The void is no longer home.

“That makes sense.”

Besides, ripping open the breach between realities without a sorcerer like Odin to seal it again could have...unfortunate consequences for your world.

“And that would be bad.”

Obviously.

I tilted back in the chair, eyes tracing the cracked plaster above me. “I’m surprised that would bother you.”

She didn’t answer.

But before I could ask again, the front door swung open with a gust of cold air blowing through the space, followed by a tall, familiar silhouette.

Nikolai.

I sunk into the chair despite myself, hand dropping from my chest as my pulse spiked—tight, fast, immediate. He had that effect on me no matter how bad my mood.

He was speaking to someone. It was Tara from circulation, I think, but his eyes were already on me.

I hadn’t answered his text, and he showed up anyway.

Of course he had.

He started toward me, long coat unbuttoned, collar turned up against the wind with that usual predatory calm in his eyes, like nothing could touch him. Like he was the one doing the choosing.

Anger wormed through in my gut.

He wanted me out of the city. He wanted me safe. And I wanted to scream at him for it.

Instead, my gaze slipped lower as he shrugged off his coat and slung it over a chair. His shirt was unbuttoned just enough to flash the line of his throat, while the sleeves were pushed back to his forearms, those ruthless hands falling loose at his sides.

And just like that, the anger coiled into something hotter, right between my thighs.

Fucking traitor, I muttered to my pussy.

Please. He's far too tasty for your sustained annoyance.

“So glad to have you back, creeper.” I exhaled, teeth finding my lower lip. “*But that man is mine.*”

Prove it.

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CHAPTER FOUR

Him

SHE LEANED AGAINST THE window, elbow propped on the armrest, temple resting on her knuckles. Her hair, half-tamed in a lazy ponytail, hung forward, catching faint highlights from the passing streetlights.

I shouldn't be doing this. Tonight's plan didn't call for chauffeur duty. Or watching her from across a car like some undersexed teenager.

But after the scene with Mercer, after seeing the body, I knew my live video feed of her wasn't enough. I needed to see her in the flesh. Breathing. Alive.

"So where are we going, anyway?" she asked. "We passed my place two streets ago."

I glanced over, just as she stretched into the dark leather, back arching, hands overhead.

"Glad to see you're paying attention." My knuckles whitened on the wheel. "It's not like there's someone out there trying to kill you."

She stilled for a beat, then turned toward me. "There was another one?"

I jerked my chin once. Yes.

"Fuck." She exhaled, blowing a strand of hair out of her face. "That's just —fuck."

I didn't answer. What could I say that she didn't already know? The dead were stacking up.

"We better not be going to the airport, Nikolai Dragunov." Her arms crossed under her chest, pushing together the soft, generous curves in a way that—my eyes wandered as I became painfully aware of every inch of her.

"We are not going to the airport." I shifted in my seat, trying to focus on her words, but the ache didn't fade.

Catching the direction of my stare, her mouth quirked up. Then she unhooked her arms with deliberate flair and crossed her legs instead. "Good. Because you wouldn't survive the attempt."

"Mmm." My gaze dipped again, down the length of her thigh, bare now. The flowing skirt had ridden high, and she hadn't moved to adjust it.

God help me.

Even when she was being an annoying brat with zero sense of self-preservation, I couldn't take my eyes off her. Had I reacted like this before the curse? Had any woman ever undone me just by existing?

A laugh escaped, deep and rough. No. I wouldn't have made it to thirty if I'd been this easily distracted in the thirteenth century.

She snapped her fingers. "Eyes up here, Dragunov. You won't avoid my question that easily."

I laughed again and let one hand slip from the wheel, reaching across the console. My fingers slipped beneath the hem of her skirt and gripped the top of her thigh—hot, firm, perfect. I squeezed, loving the way she gasped, the way her body arched ever so slightly toward me.

Color climbed up her throat, spreading under her skin as her chest rose higher and fell faster than it had a moment before.

"Home, *dulcis mors*." I squeezed again, harder this time, savoring the mark I knew my fingers would leave on her flesh. "I'm taking you home."

"Like...to your house?" she asked, her voice thinner now—more breath than bite.

Her hips turned beneath my touch, inching closer, like her body had decided to stop pretending. I didn't need to look down to know exactly where I wanted to go.

"And here I thought you just lived in my shadow," she managed, "showing up every few days to—"

I found her, and she broke off with a gasp, her spine bowing from the seat.

“Ahhh—”

Christ.

“Hmmm.” I forced my gaze back to the road, pulse hammering. “I have something special planned for you tonight.”

Pulling my hand away, I savored the slide of her warmth against my skin before bringing my fingers to my mouth. Tasting her.

“Fuck, Vera.”

Her name hit my tongue like a sin, and for a second, I nearly missed the turn, gripping the wheel with both hands, forcing focus.

I needed to be cold tonight. Controlled.

But God above, I wanted her undone first.



“Take off your shoes.”

She paused at the edge of the room, one brow lifting like she expected a punchline. I stood barefoot across from her, the floor cool beneath my feet. The scent of cedar drifted in from the open shoji-style panels on the far wall, where a faint breeze stirred the edges of sheer curtains.

She kicked off her ankle-high boots with a thud, one then the other, toeing them to the side. “So...this is your grand plan?” Her gaze swept the space, taking in the tall walls lined in clean bone-colored wood, the gleam of old blades mounted above eye level. “We’re going to, what...fight each other? Train? I don’t even get a tour first?” Her hip jutted out to the side. “Or at least a quick stop in the bedroom?”

This was going to be harder than I thought. Having her here in my space, in my home, breathing the same air—and not claiming her.

I exhaled through my nose, forcing the hunger down.

My eyes lifted to the small, framed painting that hung just left of the door—Tepui, rendered in thick strokes on stretched, raw canvas. Burnt sienna and jungle green layered in a jagged spire, the sky behind it stained in clay reds.

That place had never needed words. Neither did this one.

I turned back to her, grounding myself as I reached for the weapon resting on the table by the door. It was a simple arming sword—single-handed,

with a leather-wrapped grip darkened by years of sweat and handling. I raised it, testing the weight with a flick of my wrist, then looked down the line of the blade straight at her.

She pursed her lips, head tilting as she studied the opposite wall. Her gaze flicked from blade to blade—curved sabre, heavier Chinese dao, a wide-mouthed kukri gleaming with old use. “Do I just pick one, then?”

I didn’t answer.

I moved with three quick strides and no sound as the sword came up. My hips turned with it, blade low, then rising in a clean, merciless arc aimed for her center. No warning. No pullback.

Her expression morphed, brows lifting in surprise, mouth quirking like she thought it was a joke, cocky as hell. Then the steel caught the light, and her eyes went wide and round.

She dove left, heels skidding across the pale wood, her shoulder hitting the floor with a muffled thud.

“What the fuck, Dragunov!” She scrambled to her feet. “Not all of us come back from a sword through the gut!”

I raised my weapon, again.

“Screw you. This isn’t some weird sex game, stalker.” Her jaw locked, and her eyes didn’t leave the blade—not once. They followed the steel as it swept in low, cutting a clean crescent just above her midsection.

Pivoting, she dropped her shoulder and ducked under the attack, stumbling away from me.

Not perfect, but she was still on her feet.

Good girl.

I slid sideways, weight dropping as I lifted my knee and released a front kick into her back.

Air punched from her lungs with a wump as she crashed into the floor, then skidded hard into the far wall, skirt flaring high around her thighs.

“Get up.”

Her shoulders rose with a shuddering breath, but she didn’t move.

“I said, get up.”

Stepping closer, I dragged the tip of the metal blade along the floor, grating against the pale wood. I’d have to buff that later, but for now, the sound worked.

Head bowed, her fist trembled, then thumped against the floor.

When her face finally rose, her teeth were bared, eyes wild. “What’s the plan here, asshole? Beat me into submission until I get on a plane?”

“Is that what you want?” I took another step, sword tilting forward. “To run away?”

“No!” Her fingers curled, nails digging into the floor, leaving thin crescent divots behind.

“You’ve been hiding since the candy factory.” A frown pulled across my mouth. “Why not just leave?” I drew my leg back, lining up another kick. “Allow the men to take care of things.”

A rough sound tore from her throat—half scoff, half snarl. One foot slid back across the floor, weight folding low, ready to strike.

Yes. My muscles tensed, ready for her.

Then she lunged, hands flashing toward my throat. I turned sideways at the last second, letting her fly past with nothing but air between us.

She caught herself on the balls of her feet and spun.

I met her with a slash. Not a real one, but the edge cracked against her side all the same.

“Where is the woman I found that night by the warehouse?”

She hissed. Turned. And charged again.

I sidestepped, blade cutting across her thigh.

“Where’s the woman who hunts Chicago’s predators?”

She grunted, teeth clenched, and her elbow swung toward my temple. Bending under it, I brought the blade across her back in a light slap.

“Where is the woman,” I growled, “who drove a blade through my heart as she rode me?”

Her foot shot out in a trip attempt, but I leapt and spun, catching her shoulder with the edge. Another cut. Another well of blood.

Her snarl was wordless. Animal.

“Where’s the monster?!” I roared, smashing the tip of the sword into the floor and opening my arms. “Who came to punish the man who kidnapped and killed me with nothing but her teeth, her nails, and a knife?”

She didn’t speak, just charged again—and this time, I didn’t move.

Her body hit mine with the force of a jousting lance, driving the air from my lungs as my back struck the floor. And before I could fully register the impact, she was already on top of me—knees locked against my ribs, fingers closing around my throat with practiced, punishing intent.

“Ver...” I started.

Her grip tightened. She yanked, and my head snapped up, then slammed back down, the crack of bone against wood echoing behind my teeth as light burst across my vision.

“Is this what you want?” she snarled.

Another slam and the room spun sideways.

“You want to die, Dragunov?”

I’d taken worse. Survived worse. But I needed to be careful now. Couldn’t cross that threshold, yet. I had to stay with her through this, through all of it.

Bringing my hands up, I closed them around her arms, and one finger at a time, tore her nails loose. Then, I bucked beneath her, throwing her off me. She hit the floor, limbs already bending to rise, but I was faster. Rolling, I closed the distance and pinned her with both wrists caught in one hand above her head.

“Get off me!!” She gnashed her teeth at my face.

I didn’t recoil, and my grip didn’t loosen even as her struggles became wild.

“Get off me!”

There. Behind the anger, I saw it in the way her eyes darted, in the shallow pitch of her breathing. The fear. The panic.

“Make me.” I released one of her wrists and brought my other hand to her face, fingers digging into her jaw.

She reared and tried to jerk her head to the side, but I held firm as her arms flailed and legs kicked. It didn’t matter. She didn’t stand a chance. I was heavier. Stronger. Trained across eight centuries of wars and back-alley bloodbaths on every continent. Her rage gave her power, but not leverage. And she knew it.

I could feel the shudder starting in her chest, her resistance fraying.

“Please! Nikolai!” she choked. “I want to stop!”

I adjusted my hips, grinding down against her. The heat between us should’ve wrecked me—but I wasn’t even hard. Hurting her like this made me sick. Still, I couldn’t let her surrender.

Leering, I lowered my mouth to her ear.

“You have no power here, woman.” I teased my nose along her neck, the scent of her dread nearly gagging me. “I can do whatever I want to you.”

She froze, her entire body going taut beneath me.

Shit. I’d taken it too far.

I loosened my hold, ready to ease off—ready to roll back and apologize, to pull her out of it—

But it wasn't a whimper that escaped her throat then. No. Something rumbled. Dark and low.

“Screw you.”

I blinked, and she moved.

One second, I was on top of her; the next, her legs snapped up, catching me in a scissor-lock. My balance disappeared beneath me, and I crashed down on my side with a grunt as she rolled into a crouch.

Finally.

She surged up from the floor, blade flashing in her hand before I even saw where it came from. A flick of her wrist, a blur of silver, and the knife punched forward, straight for my heart.

Oh shit. The thought flared just as I turned, tried to dodge, and steel punched deep into the meat beneath my collarbone. Pain tore through my shoulder as the momentum spun me back until the floor hit, leaving me face down with the blade still buried deep.

Damn. That was close.

Blood spread under me, warm and fast. And now—now I was hard.

My cock pressed against the ground, the bite of it unwelcome beneath my weight, but I didn't move. Didn't groan. Didn't congratulate her or tell her well done. No. I remained still and just let the blood do the lying.

“Fuck you!” Her voice hit like broken glass. “Fuck you, asshole!”

Footsteps. Fast. Close. I felt her approaching before the first kick landed, and pain burst through my side, bright and hot. Still, I didn't move.

“I hope you stay dead this time!” Another kick. Harder. Lower.

My head spun. It felt *amazing*.

“If I knew how to fucking kill you for good, I would!” Breath coming hard and fast, she turned away. “Don't fucking call me. Ever again.”

The door slammed, and the slap of her boots echoed into the hall before silence reclaimed the space.

I waited.

Fifteen seconds. Thirty.

Only when I heard the groan of the front gate opening—*only then*—did I turn onto my side.

Fuck.

I fell onto my back, blinking up at the ceiling like it might offer forgiveness.

She was gone for now.

I knew she'd find some way to cover the blood and call a car. Only this time, it wouldn't be an actual ride share. It would be my driver standing by to pick her up. I'd made sure of it.

Her night wasn't over yet.

"Shit," I muttered, trying to push up to my elbows, fire tearing through my side.

She might've ruptured a kidney with that last kick. It didn't matter, though. I just had to last another hour. Maybe two. For what came next, she couldn't be alone. I had to be there—had to make damn sure it wasn't her blood on the floor by the time the night ended.

After that, she could take her time with me. Or do it fast if she wanted. I'd give her whatever she needed. A bodyguard had already been arranged to protect her if she chose to take me off the board.



CHAPTER FIVE

Her

THE SUV'S INTERIOR WAS dark. Hushed. But not silent—outside, the city rushed by in a smear of sodium orange and white LED.

I sat rigid, arms cinched tight across my chest. My teeth felt like they might crack from the pressure.

“Fucking psycho.”

The words weren't meant for anyone specific. Maybe the Goddess. Or maybe the ghost of Nikolai still clinging to scrapes across my skin. I didn't care. My boot kicked into the back of the passenger seat, causing the driver to flinch.

“Sorry,” I muttered. “Wasn't aiming for you.”

He didn't answer.

Turning my face to the window, I glared at the dark blur of the city. It moved too fast, too bright, like it didn't give a shit that my heart was still jackhammering, that my hands wouldn't stop shaking, that my thighs were tacky with sweat and blood.

“Did he think that would fix things?” I hissed, voice pitched for the Goddess alone. “Beat the shit out of me and hope I'd forget all about what...what happened?”

Nothing.

“Of course you’re silent now.” I dragged the back of my hand across my mouth. “You always are when it fucking matters.”

The leather beneath me was too soft. It would feel so good to fucking dig my nails in and rip it wide open. My pulse spiked, and the world cracked open with a memory I’d buried years ago.

Cold ground. Gravel biting into my back. The stink of sweat and weed. Brass screaming somewhere off in the distance, the marching band playing something too cheerful. The creak of the bleachers above. And the weight—someone on top of me, hand locked around my throat. Too strong. Too heavy. My nails scraping, slipping, trying to dig in—

“Stop.” I wrenched my gaze from the window and forcing it back. “You’re not that girl, anymore.” Panic throbbed at the base of my skull. “You’re not weak.”

That girl had begged. Had bled.

Drawing in a breath through my nose, I held it until my vision went fuzzy around the edges, then let it out.

“You take,” I said. “And never give anything you don’t want to give.”

A traffic light washed the cabin red. The glow bled across my skirt, and I stared at the rip in the fabric where Nikolai’s blade had kissed my thigh. It wasn’t deep. It had barely even stung. But it would leave a mark.

“Who the fuck does he think he is?”

The Goddess stirred.

“Don’t you fucking dare spin this,” I sputtered. “He ambushed me. Held me down. Put his hands on me like it was his right.”

The bile was back, sour and thick at the back of my throat.

“I can’t do this again,” I whispered. “Munin? Where are you?”

The SUV turned sharply, knocking my shoulder into the door.

“Nothing to say about your precious Nikolai?” I stared at the tremor running through my fingers. “You fucking signed off on him!”

From the front seat, the driver tensed. Just a flick of his eyes in the mirror.

I barked a laugh. “You probably think I’m crazy, don’t you?”

No response. Just a flicker of surprise—enough to stoke the spark already chewing through my nerves.

“Who is this crazy bitch talking to herself, right?” My nails clawed into my scalp. “Eh?”

Still nothing. Just the city sliding by, like even it didn’t want to be involved.

“Well, joke’s on you, pal.” I leaned forward enough to catch the line of his cheek. “I’m not talking to myself. I’m talking to the dark goddess who lives rent free in my fucking brain!” I threw my arms wide, laughter spilling out rough. “Ha!”

He stared straight ahead.

“Pussy.” I looked back to the window. Tired.

Smoother asphalt gave way to broken concrete, the tires thudding over old potholes that rattled up through the frame.

Are you done? The Goddess exhaled at last.

Am I done? If I could’ve reached inside my own gut and wrung her neck, I would’ve. That’s all she had to say after—after what he’d done to me?

She hummed. *How did it feel?*

“How did what feel?” The words caught in my throat. *When he cut me with that stupid sword?*

I touched one of the wounds along my belly—barely a graze, but pain jolted through like a live wire.

“It fucking hurt.”

Or how about when he pinned me? Didn’t even break a sweat holding me down like I weighed nothing. My heart beat wildly in my chest. *When I begged him to stop—and he didn’t. How about that? You want to know how that felt?*

No, dear heart. She was a dark tide pulling back from shore within me. Cold fingers brushing over my skin. *Tell me how his eyes widened when you took his head in your hands and splintered the floor beneath his skull.*

My stomach clenched, and my pulse relaxed into something dark and steady.

Tell me how it felt when your knife parted his skin, when his blood sprayed across your cheek.

My hand lifted on its own, fingertips grazing the spot where I’d wiped the blood away with one of his kitchen towels.

Tell me how his ribs caved beneath your foot when you drove it into his side.

Fuck.

“That part.” A shudder rolled through me like something heavy slipping down my back. “That part felt fucking good.”

And in those moments, were you weak?

“No.”

Were you powerless? Were you prey?

“No.” I chewed the inside of my cheek. “I felt more myself than I have in weeks.”

The fear I’d been drowning in—that constant drum—had cracked beneath anger’s weight. Smothered by fury. By bloodlust. And now that I’d tasted it again, it was like finding a grip on a slick wall. Something to hold onto. Something real enough to haul myself back up.

“Shit.” I reached for my ponytail, giving it a tug.

He’d broken the cycle. Fear, self-pity, shame—I’d been choking on it, and he cut straight through. He’d stoked my temper, and forced me to fight back, let me beat him bloody.

Shit. My stomach flipped.

“Did he let me win?”

Another pothole knocked me into the door.

He’s larger. Stronger. And has over eight hundred years of experience in actual combat, the Goddess said flatly. Then a pause. *Though...you surprised him at the end with the knife.*

She sounded proud.

“Kinda defeats the purpose, though, if he—”

The SUV jolted again, the tires bouncing hard off another dip in the pavement.

I frowned, twisted in my seat. “Where are we?”

Straining against the seatbelt, I craned forward just in time to see a massive garage door rolling upward. It opened into a dark, mostly empty warehouse—dust curling in the headlights, the concrete floor scarred with old tire tracks. A few shipping containers stood scattered like forgotten monoliths, shadows pooling between them.

“This is definitely not my apartment.” My eyes snapped to the driver. “Where the fuck are we?”

We rolled into the space, tires crunching over loose gravel.

Oh. He’s positively devious. Her chuckle danced behind my eyes before the weight of her gaze turned inward. *Prepare yourself. The dragon slayer was just a...what do you mortals call it? A warm-up.*

“Dragon what?” I was already reaching for the handle when the door swung open.

“What the f—”

A rough hand closed in my hair. The next second, my body was wrenched sideways and hauled from the seat like a ragdoll. I hit the concrete, my elbow cracking down hard, then my hip.

“I swear to God, Nikolai!” I shouted through the pain, smashing my palm against the concrete as I scrambled to one knee. “I am going to rip your fucking head off!”

The SUV reversed, sending gravel flying in jagged bits of stone into my face.

My hand flew up to block my eyes as the vehicle slid backward into the dark outside. A second later, the garage door began to lower, sealing me in.

I was going to kill him. And then I was going to wait for him to come back and kill him again. Over and over again.

You know he would just enjoy that. Her sigh fell through my thoughts.

Then the scent hit me.

It wasn't cedar and stillness, or that faint bite of oil he always carried—clean, with the ghost of spice beneath it, like steel warmed in his hands. Someone was nervous, sweating hard. Body odor mixed with the tang of old fries and rotting pickles. It clung to the air, crawling up my nose like a warning.

That wasn't Nikolai.

Before I could move, something slammed into my back.

A boot drove between my shoulder blades, full force, and breath exploded from my lungs as I pitched forward, palms slapping the concrete, knees dragging. Pain splintered up my arms and down my back as I skidded half a foot before stopping.

My vision blurred.

“You really can get anything on the internet.” The voice grated too high for a man, thin and nasal, but with something slick tucked behind it.

Footsteps echoed across the concrete as he got closer, and at the far end of the space, a side door creaked open.

Nikolai slipped through, a shadow against the harsh overhead light. He moved with one hand holding his arm in place, blood soaking through the fabric in a dark smear as he leaned against the wall and watched.

“Though this weirdo wants to watch.” The other man scratched at his chin with dirty nails, then rolled his shoulders and let them settle with an audible crack. “Came with a discount, though, so I guess it's fine.”

“Listen, pal.” I spat a thick wad of blood onto the floor between us. “You don’t want to do this. You can still leave.”

He ignored me, taking another step. Then another.

“I mean, you can get anything on the dark web. Zip ties in bulk. Tranquilizers by the dose. Tracking collars. Even those weird metal rigs with the—what do you call them—stilts?” He grinned. “And pretty young things to play with.”

He crouched in front of me, knees popping. Then, his hand reached out, knuckles brushing my cheek.

“Though.” He frowned. “You’re bigger than I ordered.”

Please tell me we can keep this one, the Goddess murmured, hunger crackling like frost down my spine. *I want to enjoy it.*

“Oh yes,” I whispered, smiling as I lifted my hand and gently wrapped my fingers around his wrist.

Icy power surged through my limbs, filling every muscle, sending my smile wider.

His brow twitched upward, and he turned his neck toward Nikolai.

“I didn’t ask for a weirdo, you freak. I wanted one that would scream.”

Nikolai didn’t answer. He just tipped his head and let it knock against the wall with a dull thud, like he couldn’t be bothered to care.

“Whatever. Fucking internet.”

The man turned back to me, and tried to yank his arm free, but my grip didn’t budge.

“Hey!” He shoved at my shoulder with his free hand, and I bared my teeth. What had been nails a second ago now stretched into points, bending against his jaw before driving into the skin and bone.

“Get off me!” His scream tore through the warehouse, high and wet as he reached for his belt, fingers fumbling for the hunting knife there. It came up fast, singing toward my throat.

Darkness swirled at the edge of my vision, and my other hand shot up, closing around his wrist.

Bone shifted, and something popped in my grip.

He gasped, and the blade slipped free. It hit the concrete with a clang, then skittered out of reach, spinning once before settling.

Now he was shaking. It wasn’t a full-body tremble, not yet. But I could feel it in the small tendons of his wrist—how they twitched in my hand. How his eyes darted toward the knife on the floor like it could save him.

I leaned in, inhaling.

“You smell delicious.”

His mouth gaped in confusion.

I licked my lips, and his eyes flared, whites flashing as he finally saw me for what I was.

My tongue—longer than it should’ve been—slipped across the air between us and flicked just beneath his ear. Salt. Adrenaline. Cheap soap and fear.

He jerked back like I’d branded him, head smacking into the container behind him.

That’s new, I thought to the Goddess, flexing my jaw as the strange muscle coiled back into my mouth.

Do you like it? she asked, giddy and bright.

I swished the tongue behind my teeth. It was slick, powerful, wrong in a way that felt so right. When it moved again, I caught the edges of something pointed—my canines, longer than before, just barely grazing the inside of my lip.

“You know what...” I grinned down at him. “I think I do.”

Pressure built in my hand until his jaw cracked with a sick, brittle snap that echoed up my arm.

Blood began to leak from the corner of his mouth, clinging to his lower lip, then sliding free—followed by a bubbling wheeze as his throat tried and failed to clear itself.

Panic. Kicking. Clawing at the air. The wild scrabbling of prey that realized the kill was coming.

And fuck. It felt so damn good.

The rush pooled low and deep, pulsing where I wanted to sink down and take until he had nothing left to give.

Yes. Munin hissed. *Nearly there*.

Bliss surged through me, crawling outward in waves too deep to be human. My limbs thrummed with it—blood humming, skin too tight to hold what moved beneath it.

Behind me, Nikolai pushed off the wall, steps echoing as he started toward us in a leisurely shuffle.

I craned my neck to watch him as he closed the distance, moving as if gravity bent differently around him. Even bleeding, there was precision in every step, violence waiting for permission.

My tongue slipped out again—unbidden, sinuous—and reached for the blood dripping from the other man's chin.

He whimpered.

Not that I could look at this asshole when Nikolai was moving toward me like that.

The Goddess wasn't speaking anymore. She swelled inside me, pleasure stretching to the edge of pain like the universe itself had burrowed into my marrow and was trying to break free.

The man in my grip made a keening sound, then, and it nearly sent me over the edge.

"Fuck." I exhaled, hips tipping just slightly as the wave crested, lowering my gaze.

Small. Pathetic. This one was everything mean and brittle in the world wrapped up in one useless little man. Then I looked back at Nikolai, opening my mouth, but before I could say anything, his brow ticked up, eyes drifting past my shoulder.

The cockroach dove—not from me, but toward a shard of rebar jutting up from the floor beside me—face first into a long, rust-streaked spike of metal.

No! The Goddess thrashed inside me.

The bar punched through his eye and out the back of his skull in one thick crunch. As he stilled, the heaviness inside me snapped. Not released, but broken, it tore loose, leaving my whole body twitching, the sudden emptiness almost painful.

Air blew from my lungs too fast.

"God damn it!" I sprung upright and drove my foot into his belly, then spun on Nikolai, rage rising to fill the void.

"What the hell—he didn't need to face-fuck the rebar like that, did he??"

Nikolai stood only a few steps away, chest rising steady with each breath. His hands flexed at his sides, opening and closing as his jaw tensed once, then again.

"Whoa." I blinked, stepping back half a foot. "You okay?"

His throat bobbed like he wanted to find words but couldn't. Instead, he closed the distance, one arm sweeping under my waist.

"Whoa—hey!" My feet left the ground. "Still mad at you, asshole. Where are we—"

He dropped me onto an old wooden crate near the edge of a container. My spine hit the surface, legs dangling, palms bracing behind me as I caught myself.

Then he planted his hands on either side of me, leaned over at the waist, and let his head drop—breathing hard, almost shaking with it.

When he finally looked up, our noses nearly touching, his voice came low. Rough.

“You can be as mad as you want later. But right now...”

Those dark eyes locked on mine.

“I’m going to devour you.”

His exhale grazed my mouth.

“Because I’m fucking starving for you, Vera.”

His hand slid beneath my skirt and ripped my panties clean off.

“Hey—” I grabbed a fistful of his hair, tried to yank him back up, but he just moaned into the pain.

At the sound, the Goddess rose again, expanding in my chest, in my gut, behind my eyes, into every tendon and nerve like floodwater against its dam.

The crate creaked as he wrenched my legs apart.

Rough stubble scraped the insides of my thighs as he buried his face between them—hot breath ghosting over soaked skin before his tongue found me.

There was no teasing. He licked into me with obscene confidence—flat and wide at first, dragging upward, before narrowing to flick at the spot that made my whole body jerk. He forced himself deeper, tongue probing, tasting like he was trying to memorize me from the inside.

My hips reared. Clutching at his hair, my fingers tangled deeper, holding on as if the only thing anchoring me to the world was the way his mouth moved against me.

He groaned into me, face dragging against my skin—cheek grazing tender flesh, every movement just shy of too much. His nose brushed my clit with each stroke, breath searing where his tongue couldn’t reach, like he knew exactly how to ruin me. Like if he didn’t wring pleasure out of me, he’d fucking die.

I couldn’t speak. Couldn’t even think.

My thighs locked around his head, muscles straining, dragging him deeper. I took his mouth, chasing the rhythm, smothering him in everything

I had. His nose pressed tight, lips sealed around me, tongue still working as I suffocated him between my legs.

He moaned again, the sound muffled and desperate, but he didn't pull back.

And I held him there with both my hands and my thighs, every nerve lit and sparking, as he let me drown him.

He wanted it. Wanted to die choking on my pussy and be reborn in the mess of it.

He didn't come up for air. And I didn't let him.

"Nikolai!" His name poured from my lips as he broke apart beneath my body.

A single, violent shudder ran through him—release and death tangled in the same heartbeat.

Pleasure ripped through me in waves, a cry tearing loose as I ground down on him. I rode it out there—on his face, in the slackening of his limbs, in the final tremor that left his body and didn't return.

His tongue stilled.

His breath vanished.

He died with my cunt on his mouth—and I came like I owned the last beat of his heart.



CHAPTER SIX

Him

WAKING WAS A RESTRAINED kind of violence.

It was the only pain untouched by pleasure, anchored in the bone where death had left its mark. Cold bled through the floor into my spine, dragging sensation back with it. The nerves were more sluggish, waking in fragments, some with fire, others barely there.

There was a heaviness against the back of my skull—supple, warm. Vera.

I cracked open an eye.

She was seated behind me, legs folded beneath the long spill of her skirt, the fabric brushing my temple like a whisper. Her back rested against the edge of the crate I'd laid her on earlier, head tipped slightly, mouth parted in sleep.

Her scent clung to me. Lavender, citrus, and the raw sweetness of her release—still fresh on my lips like a brand.

My gaze tracked the curve of her jaw, the gentle rise and fall of her generous chest, the faded bruises painting her throat like the petals of some too-dark bloom.

I remembered the exact moment her thighs had locked around my head, how she had flexed above me, dragging me deeper, leaving no space for air.

Even now, my body stirred in response—languid, involuntary, held in the echo of her slick warmth and the way she'd held me there until life fled.

Turning my head, the side of my face settled against her thigh.

She didn't stir.

I could have stayed like that for eternity—half-broken, half-rebuilt, lying at the edge of her body like a blade waiting for its sheath. But she would wake soon. And when she did, I intended to be the first thing she saw.

Ten minutes later, I eased out of her lap, careful not to disturb the arm still bent where my head had been. She murmured something wordless in her sleep, then settled again.

The warehouse loomed around us, the overhead lights humming like old ghosts.

This place had always been mine—a place to store what didn't belong anywhere else. Swords I hadn't drawn in centuries. Books written in tongues long dead. A suit of armor scorched black by dragonfire and cracked at the breastplate where something ancient had tried to punch through.

Now there'd be one more thing to add to the collection.

I looked toward the far wall where the man still hung limp, the rusted rebar pierced clean through his skull. I didn't move him. The body would keep for another day.

A smile tugged at the corner of my mouth. That was my Vera. Always leaving a mess.

Gently, I scooped her into my arms, tucking her legs against my chest. Her head lolled briefly, then landed into the crook of my neck with a sigh.

She slept the whole drive, arms loose across her stomach, head resting on the window. I kept one hand on the wheel, the other just barely brushing her side every time we hit a bump. When we got back to the house, she stirred as I carried her through the front door. Not startled—just present. And by the time I set her down, she was already standing on her own.

She didn't move further, taking in the space around her. The clean lines and pale wood stretching up along the walls and into open beams overhead. I hadn't given her much time to observe the space when we'd come here earlier.

"Kitchen's down the hall," I said. "Guest room's yours, if you want space."

She didn't answer right away. Just looked at the floor, then back at me, then wandered off like she already lived here.

Twenty minutes later, she stepped out into the kitchen in one of my shirts—bare legs, damp hair, expression unreadable. She said nothing as she walked past me into the living room and dropped onto the couch, snuggling into the smooth leather.

I handed her a bottle of water and sat across from her, watching.

She fell back asleep with the bottle still tucked against her chest.



The grinder rasped in slow, deliberate rotations. Each turn pulled the scent of espresso into the kitchen—deep, bitter, alive with oil and heat. They were dark-roast, single-origin beans. I'd chosen them for her, rather than myself.

Keeping the rhythm steady, focused, my hands worked on instinct. It was the kind of motion that dulled thought, or at least kept it from circling the same question.

Had I pushed her too far?

Sex—violent, ecstatic as it was—wasn't clarity. It didn't mean forgiveness. It didn't mean anything, not really, unless she wanted it to. And if she didn't—

Beside me, bacon sizzled in the skillet, turning up at the edges in its own crackling rhythm.

When she entered the room, her pace was measured. Each step was purposeful with none of the hesitation I half expected.

Glancing over my shoulder, I found her standing at the island countertop, arms loosely crossed over her chest. Her face was still unreadable as she watched me for a moment before speaking.

"I understand why you did it." Her voice carried no kindness, but no malice either. "Or at least, I think I do."

I didn't look away from the pan, letting the sizzle cover the sound of breath I hadn't meant to hold. She wasn't yelling. She wasn't lashing out, though the steel in her voice had more edge than a blade.

"But what you did in the training room wasn't okay." Her words dropped cleanly between us. "Don't do it again."

I nodded once. The muscles across my shoulders refused to release.

Stepping forward, she closed the distance between us, the hem of my shirt skimming her thighs with each movement. Her mouth parted like she might add something more.

Instead, she rose up on her toes and kissed me.

It wasn't deep, or driven by hunger or need. It was simply the touch of her lips against mine.

"Thank you," she whispered, as her heels returned to the floor.

My hand found her hip, fingers splaying over the curve without thought, though I didn't pull her closer. She lingered there, between words and decisions, and I let her.

Eventually, she glanced toward the coffee press and lifted her chin.

"Please tell me you have real sugar."

I reached without a word and slid the bowl across the counter toward her. It was cut glass, heavy and old. She eyed it suspiciously, then grabbed the spoon and shoveled in a heap. Then another. Then a third.

I arched a brow.

She met my gaze, daring me to comment as she stirred.

I turned back to the skillet. By the time she disappeared down the hall, taking the coffee with her, the bacon was already done.

A few minutes later, I heard the door to the guest room open. Then the drag of something across the floor. A zipper. Another. The muted sound of hangers knocking together.

When I turned, she was walking into my bedroom, arms full with the stack of clothes and toiletries I'd had brought over from her apartment. When I popped my head in with a full plate in hand, she was folding her robe over the end of the bed.

"This was a little much," she said, holding her special mug. "You really are a stalker bastard. "How did you even get into my apartment without a key."

I set the plate down on the dresser and smiled. "You needed it."

She didn't argue, just rolled her eyes and placed the mug on the nightstand—beside mine—and followed me back to the kitchen.



I drove her to work every day that week.

She called it overbearing, “weird,” even. Claimed it was an inconvenience.

But every morning, she came thundering down the stairs at the last possible second—”Move your ass,” already out of her mouth—boot half-zipped, coat slung over one shoulder, grabbing the coffee straight out of my hand.

And she’d huff, waiting just long enough for me to open the car door before sliding into the passenger seat—leggings, oversized sweater, and scarf knotted like armor.

She’d keep her face angled toward the window, never thanking me, but I caught the corner of her mouth pulling up more than once.

Most days, I’d stay in the library, posted at one of the reading tables near the back. From there, I could see her at the circulation desk, sorting donation cards, checking vendor schedules, flipping through a clipboard with her brow furrowed in concentration. She moved with purpose, shoulders squared, every motion tight and efficient.

Every now and then, though, when she thought no one was watching, she’d pause to tug a curl behind her ear, letting her weight settle into one hip. And for a breath, she looked... lighter.

She glared at me every time she caught me watching.

She also brought me lunch every day.

Either way, I had no intention of leaving her alone—at least not until the gala was over, or the killer was caught. Whichever came first.

Until then, she was in my sight. Always.



The call from Mercer came just after six a.m. Thursday morning.

No new bodies, but they'd found something. It was a single shoelace soaked in blood, tucked behind the scorched foundation of the occult shop that burned down last month. At first glance, it looked like trash. But the way it was knotted matched evidence found at the other scenes.

It wasn't enough to make an arrest, but it gave Mercer something to chase—a suspect last seen loitering outside a popular nightclub. Homeless, or pretending to be.

I ended the call in silence. Maybe Mercer would handle it, and they'd find the killer before he set his sights on Vera again.

I could hope, but I wasn't counting on it.

Down the hall, the shower kicked on, followed by the faint thud of her shampoo bottle hitting the tile. She always dropped it and never picked it up without a stream of curses. I turned back to the stove, poured the eggs into the pan, and reached for the fresh orange juice I'd pressed an hour earlier.

By the time she came into the kitchen, steam still clinging to her skin, she was already talking.

"Do not say a single word about my shirt."

It was a faded black tee that read **I'll Sleep When I'm Dead** across the chest. Her hair was damp and piled into a messy knot she'd have to fix if she ever wanted to get a brush through it. She poured herself coffee—straight into that neon mug—and climbed onto the stool as I passed her a plate.

She raised an eyebrow when she saw the sausage.

"Bribing me for a blowjob later?" she asked, casual as anything, spinning her fork between her fingers. "As payment for the warehouse?"

"Trust me—there's nothing to pay back. I got more out of that than you did." I didn't even look up from the eggs.

Pleased, she turned back to her food, her cheeks flushed a bright red.

We ate in relative quiet. She scrolled through her phone, complaining about vendor confirmations and Margaret's weird insistence on thematic book displays. I let her vent while I checked the final details for our trip after the gala.

Holbox. Remote. Private. The villa I'd booked sat at the edge of the sand with no neighbors for miles and no cars allowed on the island. Sun and space for her to breathe again.

I was halfway through finalizing her packing list when a new message came through. I stared at the email again, jaw tightening.

Courier's out sick. Dress must be retrieved in person. No exceptions.

"Damn it all." I set my phone down hard enough to rattle the countertop. The last thing I wanted was to leave her, especially now. But there was no way in hell I was letting anyone else handle that gown.

I shot off a quick text to Walker, the off-duty detective I'd had on standby all week.

Change of plans. You're on her. Stay close. Don't be seen.

Then I grabbed my coat before I turned back to face her.

She was still working through her coffee when I tossed her the keys to the Jaguar.

"Something's come up. You'll need to drive yourself in today."

She caught them. "Seriously?"

"Don't wreck it."

"That a challenge?" Her smirk curved.

"No." I grabbed the keys to the range rover and opened the garage door. "I'm just bracing for the call when you blow the transmission trying to outgun a garbage truck." I paused just long enough to meet her eyes again. "But I'll pick up something good for lunch. Something...special."

Then I stepped out, letting the door close behind me before I could change my mind, telling myself I'd only be away for an hour or two. It was eight in the morning. What could go wrong?



CHAPTER SEVEN

Her

NIKOLAI'S JAG HANDLED LIKE a dream and sounded like a threat. Sleek, predatory, all forward momentum with a growl tucked just beneath the hood.

Still, it was the first time all week I'd had more than five feet of personal space and no eyes on me.

No Nikolai. No sidelong glances over the rim of his mug. No looming presence at my elbow while I filed invoices or yelled at delivery drivers. No heat in my belly from the weight of his gaze while I tried and failed to concentrate on work while he brooded in the back of the library like an exhibit.

It was just me, the wheel, and the city slipping past in a blur of steel and late October gray.

Freedom.

Except I kind of hated it.

"Well," I muttered, tapping my fingers against the leather-wrapped steering wheel, "this is fucking weird."

The Goddess stirred. *Missing your shadow already?*

"No," I said flatly. "I'm reveling in the silence. Breathing deep. Marinating in the sacred and all-too-rare joy of not having a man within ten

feet of me.”

A man who makes you coffee. And buys you underthings you didn't ask for. And lets you smother him to death between your thighs.

“Crude.” My lips pursed. “But not wrong.”

Her laugh shimmered through me. Here you are. Free of him. Alone, for the first time in days, yet still speaking his name. Still wearing his jacket. Driving his car.

“Don't get smug.”

Too late for that.

“Fine. Let's change the subject.” I exhaled through my nose, fingers flexing on the wheel. “We gonna talk about the claws? The tongue? The fangs? Because I've got questions.”

You were simply yourself. She paused. Perhaps more fully yourself than you've ever been.

I barked a laugh. “Right. Nothing says Vera Lance like crushing a man's jaw off with monster strength in a warehouse filled with eight centuries of hoarded trauma.”

It was the first time your spirit tried to wake in your flesh, the Goddess said, quieter now. You've kept it buried a long time. I gave it space to breathe.

“Wow,” I drawled, turning off Lake Shore onto Monroe. “What a gift. More teeth and self-loathing. Can't wait to write that in the gratitude journal.”

Yes. You're running up quite a tab. Good thing I like you.

“Lucky me.”

The library came into view—a long sprawl of stone and glass tucked between two taller buildings, like it had squatted down and refused to move when the city grew up around it. I pulled into the small staff lot on the side and cut the engine. Margaret's car sat two spots over, the old Honda that always looked one hard frost away from giving up.

But the building itself was still dark. No lights behind the front windows. No familiar flicker of the entryway sensor.

I frowned, reaching for my bag.

“Okay.” I stepped out into the chill. “That's weird.”

It wasn't warehouse-weird, or Goddess-in-my-bones weird. But still... off.

And I'd learned the hard way not to ignore that feeling.

Stepping toward the library entrance, my boot heels knocked dull against the pavement.

My palm drifted to the knife sheathed at my waist—fingers brushing the hilt in a nervous tic. Cold metal, smooth leather. Would it be enough against whatever made the hairs rise on the back of my neck. Or was I being paranoid? Maybe I should learn to use a gun.

When you have claws?

Easy for you to say, I shot back. You're a disembodied murder ghost. You don't have to worry about little things like bullet holes in your chest.

True. Though I quite like your chest. Very comfortable. She slunk behind my ribs, stretching languidly. Purring without sound. *I would hate to add a draft.*

“Twat.” I rolled my eyes as the library loomed ahead. Still no lights inside, or movement through the long row of windows. I scanned behind me for any sign of Nikolai and his absurd coat.

Nothing.

“Fuck.” My gut flipped, and I flattened against the outer wall like some half-baked creeper. “What do we do?”

Pressing my face to the glass revealed shadows stretching long across the marble floor, and only darkness beyond. There was no desk lamp glow, or movement anywhere. But just past the circulation desk, a sliver of something caught the ambient light. It was a smooth edge jutting into view from behind the counter.

I recognized the armrest as my fingers found the hilt at my waist again.

Is there another entrance? Munin finally spoke. *Your instincts may be right to advise caution, little monster. I do not like the smell of this place.*

Great. Even the Goddess sounded nervous.

I glanced around the lot again, heart knocking harder now. Still no Nikolai. And Margaret's car was squatting in its usual spot like it had been there for hours.

Shit.

Whatever was going on inside, Margaret was probably in the middle of it. And I couldn't walk away from her. She was practically family. My jaw I clenched so tight it clicked. She was the one who brought me tea after every panic attack junior year, showed me how to rebuild myself in books. She even wrote my college recommendation letter and made sure I had a safe place to come to work every day after that.

If something had happened to her. No. I shook my head. Nothing had happened, and I wouldn't let anything happen.

My pulse spiked, hard and fast, the way it always did right before everything spiraled. My skin prickled, palms damp.

Closing my eyes, I inhaled deep.

And somewhere under the panic—under the fragile human skin and the voice still screaming run—something waited. I'd always believed she was the one making me hunt. Hurt people. Kill. But maybe that monster had been there all along. Buried deep, waiting for air.

Yesss, she whispered.

The girl who'd begged in high school, and the woman who nearly bled out on a factory floor because a coworker went feral—she didn't exist anymore.

My fingers flexed, and beneath my skin, I could feel the memory of claws and the echo of teeth.

I was a goddamn monster. They should be afraid of me.

Yesss.

My eyes opened, and I pushed off the wall, starting toward the back. The alley was narrow, the brick damp, dumpsters reeking faintly of bleach and rot. The storage door sat ahead—paint flaking, frame slightly warped. It opened into the deepest part of the library.

I didn't hesitate.

Not this time.



My hands were slick—blood, sweat, maybe both. It coated my palm, warm and tacky, like proof I hadn't dreamed this. Margaret was sobbing behind me, low and ragged. One arm still lashed to the chair. Her blouse hung off one shoulder, streaked with dust and something darker.

Across the room, the man—no, the thing—smiled. But the expression didn't belong to the skin it wore. The cheeks were wrong, too tight. The eyes glowing behind the human blue were ancient and knowing as they watched me through a face that twitched every time it tried to speak.

Hunin.

I saw him now—the hungry ripple of shadow coiled just beneath the flesh. He was the oily shimmer at the edges of the man’s outline.

Nikolai would come. I just needed to keep Margaret safe until then.

He tilted his head.

Then the door wooshed open.

“Thank God.” I sagged a little against the desk I’d been using to hold myself up.

But instead of Nikolai, Mercer burst into the room, gun raised. “Hands —!”

The man didn’t flinch, just turned his head like he’d been expecting him.

“You’re making yourself a nuisance, Lieutenant,” he said. Voice low. Silken. Rotten with amusement. “But I will give you a gift for your persistence.”

A long, deliberate breath spilled from his mouth in a wave of red mist—smoke rising from a dying ember. It twisted once in the air, tendrils writhing, then slipped free of the man’s skin entirely.

The body shuddered, eyes rolling back. Then his knees buckled, dropping him like the puppet he was.

Mercer’s shout echoed behind him. “Down! Hands—now!”

Blue uniforms swarmed the room—shouting, sweeping, radios crackling in every direction. One officer kicked the man’s gun away. Another pulled Margaret loose from her chair. Someone else aimed a flashlight into my eyes.

“Ma’am! Are you okay?”

I didn’t move.

Margaret was weeping now, breath hitching in a way that hurt to hear. Mercer had two hands on the downed man, shoving him face-first to the floor, even as he threw a look back toward the place Hunin’s mist had vanished.

He didn’t understand what had happened. Neither did I, not entirely, but the tight knot in my throat loosened half a breath. By the time the spirit found another host, I’d be on a beach somewhere with Nikolai, far away from here.

This wasn’t over. But—for now—it was done.

I turned without a word, walked behind the circulation desk, and placed the knife gently on the counter. The metal hit wood with a clink, catching the fluorescents as it settled.

My reflection shimmered across the blade—lips parted, eyes wide, blood still drying beneath my nails.

I stared at it a moment longer.

Then I looked past it, out across the familiar shape of the library, broken now by chaos. I listened to the voices rising, the scrape of a chair being moved, the shuffle of uniforms and the creak of leather holsters.

And I wondered if they'd still expect me to open at ten, or if the gala was still on for tomorrow night. It'd be a shame to cancel this late in the game.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

Him

THE DRESS WAS EXQUISITE.

I'd expected it to be good. I hadn't expected to be impressed.

Steel and silk, dark as hematite, molded to a silhouette meant for war. The corset boning was carved with a jeweler's precision—sharp enough to cut if worn wrong. And from the collarbone down, rubies dripped like blood drawn in ribbons, catching the light as if they'd been forged instead of set.

I couldn't wait to see her face when she saw herself in it. Still had to figure out how I was going to get her into the damn thing without letting her see it first. Probably something tongue related.

My mouth curved at the thought.

She'd pretend not to care at first, would call it "extra" or "ridiculous." But I knew the way her hands fluttered when she was touched by something unexpected. I knew the instinctive bite of her tongue when she didn't want to show how much she liked something, and how she only felt beautiful with a knife in her hand no matter how much I stared or drooled.

At a stoplight, I checked my phone.

Nothing.

No message. No emoji. Not even a snide comment about the ancient coffee machine at the library eating another filter.

She always sent something, even if I was just down the hall. Yesterday, she'd fired off a string of emojis—👮🏻💧🍆—and followed it with “your dick’s blocking the printer.”

It had only been an hour or two.

Still. The absence sat wrong.

I glanced up as the light changed only to catch the flicker of blue and red in the corner of my eye.

No.

My foot slammed down.

The Range Rover jumped forward, engine rumbling as I cut across two lanes and took the next left too hard. The tires shrieked. A horn blared behind me. I didn't care. Another block. One more turn.

The lights came into view—police cruisers lined the curb, doors left open, red and blue strobes splashing across the library's pale stone façade. The reflections pulsed against the glass like a warning that I was already too late.

“God help me.” My throat had gone dry. “If something's happened to her —”

Pulling into the lot, I barely braked, weaving between two squad cars, nearly grazing a side mirror to get as close as possible. I parked sideways across the curb, leapt out, and ran for the doors.

The cruisers flanked the library entrance like sentries, doors ajar, radios squawking from the dash. Two uniforms stepped forward the second I pulled up, hands already hovering near their holsters.

“Sir, you can't be here. Step back.”

I didn't stop moving. “Get out of my way.”

They planted their boots and squared their shoulders.

“You heard him.” The taller of the two reached for cuffs. “Step back or we put you down. Last warning.”

“I don't have time for this—” My voice caught, barely human.

They moved. Hands closed on my arms, trying to maneuver me toward the hood of a nearby cruiser. I let them, allowing the weight of my body turn enough to gauge how easily I could snap the wrist braced against my forearm. One twist. One jerk of muscle and tendon.

But that would get me nowhere.

“Mercer!” I roared, voice echoing down the stone steps and through the half-open door. “Mercer! I know you're in there. Tell your men to stand

down before—”

“Before you what, Dragunov?”

I craned my neck to see Mercer stepping through the door, descending the steps with maddening calm. He looked down at his watch.

“A whole hour. Took you longer to get here than I thought it would.”

He gave the officers holding me a nod.

“You sure, Lieutenant?” one of them asked, brushing his thumb over his baton. “It’s almost time for my break, but I’d enjoy dragging his ass to holding for you.”

The muscle along my jaw flexed. No words, but... It would be very easy to kill these fine officers.

Mercer saw it, and his mouth twitched.

“One of these days, Dragunov.” He squeezed the bridge of his nose. “You and I are going to have words.” Then a sigh and a tilt of his head to the uniforms. “Let him go.”

They stepped aside, and I shouldered past them, the edges of my coat flaring as I brushed through.

“She’s okay?” My voice was already half a growl.

Mercer didn’t answer right away. He turned, pushed open the library’s front doors with a shoulder, then motioned for me to follow.

“Yeah,” he said as we crossed the threshold. “A bit over-excited from her... encounter. But fine.”

I caught the hitch in his step. “Her encounter?” My boots echoed off the marble as I closed the distance between us. “He was here?”

“Yeah.” Mercer stopped just shy of the circulation desk, a dry chuckle under his breath. “Hell of a fighter, that one. I’d try recruiting her if I didn’t think she’d scare half my squad into early retirement.”

“Go on. She’s in the office. Paramedics are still with the other librarian. And forensics are piecing together what’s left of Dean Walker.” His eyes flicked toward the back stacks. “I assume you hired him to watch her.”

“Yes.” I hesitated, then looked at him. “What the hell happened here?”

Mercer exhaled, dragging his fingers through his hair as he glanced back at the blood still drying in streaks near the baseboard.

“Well...” he muttered, scratching his chin. “I think I’ll let her tell you.”



I stepped past the wreckage without stopping. Shelves lay cracked along the aisles, their spines jutting like broken bones. Books sprawled across the floor in disordered stacks, pages splayed wide, some torn, some soaked.

None of it mattered when she was somewhere beyond it.

Then, I heard them—voices low, familiar, full of affection.

“You really should go to the hospital,” Vera said. “Those burns on your arms need to be looked at.”

“I’ve already told you I’m fine,” Margaret replied, exasperation easing her tone. “If anyone should go in, it’s you, dear. You could have a concussion.”

I moved faster, turning the last corner before the back office and stepping through the open door.

“A concussion?” My voice came harsher than I meant. “Christ, Vera—”

She looked up at me as I crossed the threshold. Her face was pale beneath the mess of curls, dried blood flecking her hairline. I was already reaching for her—hands at her cheeks, at her shoulders, sweeping down her arms to check for injuries she hadn’t mentioned.

“My God.” I cupped her jaw gently. “I should have been here. I’m so sorry.”

She swatted me off with a huff, but her smirk didn’t quite mask the flicker of relief in her eyes.

“I’m fine,” she said, voice dry. “Just a short run-in with an overly aggressive bookcase.”

She rubbed at the back of her head, then glanced at her palm. Blood. It wasn’t much, but my stomach still went cold.

I caught her wrist before she could pull it away and turned her hand over in mine. Then reached behind her head, fingertips barely brushing the wound.

“I promise.” She winced. “I’m fine.”

Then that smile—lopsided, ridiculous, hers.

“Tis but a scratch.”

“Saints in Heaven, Vera. Really?” I groaned, pulling a hand down my face.

“Tell that to the British History section.” Margaret snorted from the chair beside her.

Shifting like she meant to stand, one hand braced against the armrest, until her knees buckled beneath her.

Vera slipped from my grasp before I could catch her, hands steady as she guided Margaret back into the chair.

“I’m sure.” She kneeled beside the older librarian, reaching for the older woman’s hand, and giving it a warm, grounding squeeze. “I’m sorry you got dragged into this.”

“The handsome lieutenant explained everything.” Margaret’s lined face was pinched with concern, her fingers tightening around Vera’s. “That David was part of some group—men targeting women, and that they’d been...stalking you.” Her voice cracked. A single tear broke loose, slipping down her cheek. “I’m so sorry I let him into our home.”

Her hands shook.

“This place was supposed to be safe for you. I promised you that when you took this job.”

Safe place. I frowned, glancing between them. A splintering ache burned behind my lungs, each breath thinner than the last.

“Please don’t blame yourself, Margaret,” Vera said. “You’ve taken better care of me than anyone—my own parents included.”

That anger surged again. Whoever made her feel unsafe—if they weren’t already dead, they would be.

Margaret winced like she wanted to say something more, but instead, she sealed her lips into a firm line. “Your mother is...” Her words trailed off. Then she exhaled. “Not worth the discussion today.”

“When is she ever?” A pointed roll of Vera’s eyes flowed into a smile.

They exchanged a look I couldn’t quite read, and something unspoken passed between them.

Then Margaret sniffed once, composed herself, and waved a hand toward the door.

“You know,” she said, “you don’t have to go tomorrow. To the gala. No one would blame you.”

Vera stood, brushed the blood from her palm on her leggings, and straightened.

“No.” She tipped her chin up, fire glinting behind her eyes. “I want to go. Hell, I’m actually excited.”

“Excited?” I raised a brow. “That’s new.”

“Well.” She turned toward me with a crooked grin. “The killer’s caught, the drinks have been ordered, and I look damn good in heels.”

She paused.

“Right?”

I looked her up and down. “You have no idea.”



The kitchen breathed around us—dim light from the pendant above casting a warm gold sheen over dark quartz counters. The lines of the cabinetry were Scandinavian in design but softened by the sprawl of trailing green vines I let climb unchecked along the shelving. Somewhere in the other room, the low wail of Zeppelin bled through the speaker, just audible beneath the hush.

She sat at the bar like she was trying not to fidget—knees pulled up on the stool, one heel tapping against the chrome footrest. Her hair was still damp from the shower, skin scrubbed clean of blood, but I hadn’t stopped seeing it.

The worst of it was over. The spirit’s host—the new one—was in custody. Whatever was riding him had lost its tether, at least for now. That gave us time enough to regroup. I’d be able to get her out of the city before things turned again.

But my body hadn’t caught up. Not entirely. Even here, surrounded by order, my senses tracked to her.

“I really should have stayed.” She bit her lip again, just enough to leave a shallow dent behind, then glanced up at me.

“You stayed for two hours getting Stephanie up to speed on everything that needs checking before the gala tomorrow.”

“Yeah, I suppose you’re right.” She exhaled through her nose, blowing a rogue curl from her lashes. “It just feels wrong to dump it all on her like that.” Her fingers traced the grain of the bar top. “Though I still have a lot to do just to get myself ready for tomorrow.”

I turned, stepping toward the cabinet.

“As the organizer, I’ll have to introduce the mayor,” she went on, words accelerating now. “Which means standing up in front of everyone and talking.” A groan, then a sharp intake of breath. “Fuck! I don’t even have a dress yet.”

I pulled the Macallan from the shelf and reached for the crystal tumblers, their edges catching the soft light like distant fire. Pouring, I let myself watch her.

She was a storm compacted into generous curves. A constant current of motion and heat that didn’t belong in a space so deliberately curated, and yet... nothing ever looked better at my bar.

“You hang out with a fancy-ass crowd for work, don’t you?” she asked suddenly.

I barked a laugh, quick and mirthless. “Hanging out is a strong term for the occasional meeting and networking event.”

She took the glass I offered and stared into it for a beat, the amber swirl mirroring in her eyes.

“Uh-huh,” she said, more to the drink than to me. Then she lifted it, took a sip, keeping her gaze steady on the rim. “I don’t suppose you’d know someone who could help with a dress on short notice.”

Another sip, and she set the glass down, just shy of the coaster, then moved it into place with the edge of one finger.

“I mean...” She gestured vaguely toward the room. “You obviously have the means. But I hate to ask. People probably ask you for favors all the time.”

My mouth parted, then shut again.

She was serious.

Was she really this hesitant to ask me for help?

I’d planned the whole damn thing over a week ago. Picked the fabric myself. Sat with the designer and described the way her body moved. I had wanted it to be a surprise, but watching her stumble over the question like she didn’t have the right to ask...

“Vera.” I let the corner of my mouth pull up. “What makes you think I haven’t already taken care of this for you?”

“Really?” She looked up from the glass. Then her eyes narrowed. “You think you know my style?”

“Your style?”

Her mouth opened—something biting already loaded on her tongue—but I closed the distance before she could get it out. One stride. Then another. I stopped at the edge of the stool, looking down at her.

Her focus slipped. It was only for a second as if someone else looked through her eyes, trying to remember what it felt like to wear skin.

“What did she say?” I asked.

“Nothing special.” Her palm pushed into my chest, fingers flexing once over the fabric of my shirt. “Just voicing concern over your ability to pick a dress.”

The words were calm, but something jolted through her. A twitch—not harsh enough to be called a flinch, but not hers either.

I raised a brow. “Is that what she said?”

“Uppity cunt,” Vera muttered. “Fine. She may have shared her enthusiastic support for your fashion sense.”

Another flicker and her fingers twitched again.

I leaned in, let my breath ghost over her cheek until my mouth hovered beside her ear.

“Is that all she said?”

Instead of answering, her hand reached for my pants, nails skimming the edge of the waistband before slipping lower and wrapping tight around my cock.

“Damn it, Vera.” The breath ripped out of me as I surged into her grip—hard, hot, desperate. Her other hand fisted into the hair at the base of my skull, anchoring me there with a sound that was somewhere between a hum and a purr.

“Do you want to stand here and dissect the word choice of my live-in hitchhiker,” she whispered, “or do you want to let me show you how grateful I can be for everything you’ve done this week?”

Her mouth found my ear—teeth grazing the edge, tongue following.

I swallowed, hard. Thoughts scattered. Every inch of composure I had built over centuries faltered under her touch, her voice, her breath. I forgot whatever clever line I’d meant to say.

She nuzzled closer into my neck, her nose skimming skin like she already knew the places that would unmake me. Then, she dragged her lips lower—slow and claiming.

“Let me worship you tonight.”

The last thread of my restraint snapped.

I scooped her up in one fluid motion, hands locked beneath her thighs. She came willingly, legs wrapping around my waist, body flush against mine like she belonged there.

She did.

Her mouth caught mine as I moved—blind to everything but her. I carried her through the house like a man chasing his own gravity.

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CHAPTER NINE

Her

THE FIRST THING I noticed was the sunlight.

Late-morning slid through the window blinds in wide golden stripes, warming the sheets and the edge of my bare hip. I didn't open my eyes, letting the heat sink in as I catalogued the damage.

Jaw? Sore.

Thighs? Useless.

Vag? Felt like I'd run a marathon with a smile on my face and a baseball bat between my legs.

Still. I felt more rested than I had in weeks.

Stretched out across the ridiculously oversized bed in Nikolai's ridiculously quiet house, my body buzzed in places I'd forgotten had nerve endings. His sheets smelled like him—clean, warm, spiced with whatever he used to launder his shirts. I burrowed into the pillow with a groan and immediately regretted it as my neck popped in protest.

You could at least say thank you. If I hadn't kept you standing through half of that, you'd be face down in the carpet.

I cracked an eye open. "Fuck. I forgot to kick you out."

The Goddess yawned in my head, all silk and smug.

Oh no, little monster. You didn't forget. You just got too busy moaning his name with his cock halfway down your throat.

"I'm gonna need you to never say that again," I muttered, voice raspy.

Why? Because it's true? You were singing his name like prayer. But don't worry, I don't judge. I was singing right alongside of you. She paused. *Or... inside of you? You get the idea.*

I flipped the sheet over my face with a groan. "You're impossible."

And you're welcome. I kept my mouth shut while he did absolutely filthy things to you for four hours straight. That kind of restraint deserves a thank-you.

"Okay. Done." I rolled to the edge of the bed, just in time for a wave of something obscene to hit my nose.

Bacon. Not the cheap greasy kind either—thick-cut, maple glazed, probably cooked with some kind of artisanal reduction that had no business being involved with breakfast. Coffee, too—dark and nutty with a hint of cardamom, judging by the way my mouth started watering on instinct. And—was that chocolate?

The door creaked open, and I didn't have to lift my head to know it was him.

Nikolai stepped in, tray in hand. Shirtless, because why the fuck not.

He wore black joggers that barely clung on his hips, a hint of muscle flexing in his stomach as he crossed the room with effortless grace. His hair had dried in loose waves, brushing his collarbones. He'd been letting it grow since we met, and now it kissed the tops of his shoulders like he'd walked off the cover of some elf-lord bodice-ripper.

My body didn't care that I'd just spent the night riding him like a damn carousel.

It perked up. Immediately.

He set the tray down beside me on the bed. Croissants that gleamed like lacquered treasure, still warm, steam rising from their split seams. The chocolate inside was dark and molten, like it would stain my fingers and my soul if I touched it. The coffee was housed in a handmade ceramic mug, the kind that probably cost more than my shoes, with a crema so rich it looked like it had been painted on.

He plucked a piece of bacon off the plate and bit into it.

I blinked. "Excuse you."

He chewed, then smiled faintly. "I cooked it."

“Correction. You made it for me. Which means your fingers are now fair game for retribution.”

“Is that so?”

I sat up, sheets sliding off my bare chest like an invitation. His eyes dipped, lingered, and darkened.

“I’m just saying.” I leaned in just enough to feel the tension sharpen between us. “You touch another one of my croissants, and I might have to take something from you in return.”

A brow arched. “Like what?”

My gaze dragged over his stomach, the faint trail of hair leading downward. “Clothes. Dignity. Control. Dealer’s choice.”

My body pulsed in response to the thought—hungry all over again in a way that had nothing to do with food. I was sore, but not sore enough to care. His skin called to mine, and I didn’t feel like resisting.

“I don’t know if we have time for that.” He took a sip of my coffee. The bastard.

I reached for my phone. Stephanie had sent two updates already. The caterers were early. The AV techs were set. The mayor’s assistant had confirmed their arrival window.

So far, everything was under control. “I don’t need to be at the library until five to kick things off. Plenty of time to make you beg.”

I bit into the croissant, and the chocolate practically groaned.

“Any other day.” He reached for one, plucking the flakiest from the pile. “I’d happily bare my throat for you.”

My brows lifted, amused.

“But...” He glanced at the clock on the back wall. “Today? We’re already behind schedule. You slept like the dead.” He stood, stretched—just enough for his abs to flex—then walked toward the bathroom. “And snored like a deranged zombie trying to find its mate.”

“What!?” I choked on pastry, bolting upright.

He disappeared around the corner, reappearing a second later with my robe slung over one arm.

“I do not snore,” I said, crossing my arms.

“Tell that to the residents of Lincoln Park.” He tossed the plush garment onto the bed, unbothered and entirely too pleased with himself.

“Actually...better make that everyone north of the Loop.”

“Screw you, Dragunov.” I hurled a croissant at his face.

Catching it one-handed, he took a bite mid-turn and licked the flakes off his fingers.

“Later,” he said, voice dark with promise. Then he crossed to the dresser, pulled a shirt from the drawer, and shook it out with crisp efficiency.

“Now finish eating and let’s go. The seamstress wants to make sure everything squeezes and pops in just the right way.”

I squinted. “Did you just describe a ball gown like it’s a tactical lift-and-support system for my boobs?”

He shrugged, slipping the shirt on, the fabric hugging the broad muscles across his back. “I gave her a very specific vision.”



“A very specific vision indeed,” I muttered, turning on the round platform the seamstress had dragged in with theatrical flair and military-grade efficiency.

The full-length mirrors flanking the wall caught every angle—harsh, brilliant, inescapable.

“What the hell, Nikolai?” I turned toward him, dragging my hands down the sides of the dress. The silk clung to my palms like liquid armor, cool and impossibly smooth. The steel boning cut against my ribs, cinching me in like it had been tailored to my bones, not my measurements. Even the rubies—dark, blood-bright—felt heavier than they looked.

“This...this is too much.”

He frowned but said nothing.

“Seriously,” I went on, voice pitching higher. “This is meant for a queen or some... I don’t know—”

Dark goddess? Munin whispered, all velvet and smoke.

“Exactly!” I snapped, spinning again, the hem flaring slightly around my calves. “This is for someone like you,” I added. “Not me. Not a short, not-quite-fit librarian with a temper problem and a caffeine addiction.”

It’s exhausting how little you see of yourself.

I opened my mouth to tell her where she could stick her divine commentary, but the words caught.

Darkness poured from my throat in a mist laced with shadow. It flowed out of me in leisurely, sinuous waves, before rising to the ceiling. Then it twisted, collapsing inward on itself—feathers taking shape midair. A raven the size of a small dog unfurled from the cloud and landed, talons first, on top of the tallest mirror.

She preened once, then snapped her wings tight.

“Fix her, dragon slayer,” the bird croaked. “I have no patience for self-pity.”

Then she leapt, beat her wings once with a noise like a leather whip, and disappeared through the ceiling.

I bent forward, panting, hands braced on my knees.

“What the fuck, Munin.” My voice came ragged as I straightened, jaw aching. I worked it back and forth with one hand, then coughed.

When I looked up, Nikolai was staring with wide open eyes. He mouthed *what* before shaking his head. “Has she always been able to do that?”

“No,” I grumbled. “Just since the rune stone. Guess it gave her some...freedom.”

“Okay.” He took a cautious step closer. “And where does she go?”

I crossed my arms carefully, so I didn’t impale myself on the corset boning. “Mostly to spy on Lieutenant Mercer. I think she has a crush.”

He huffed a laugh. “Okay...and Munin? Like Odin’s raven?”

“Yeah. What is this, a pop quiz?”

He raised both hands. “Sorry. We can come back to it.” Another step closer. Even standing on the platform, I still had to tilt my chin up to meet his eyes.

“For now.” He rested one hand on my shoulder. “I have orders from the cranky bird, and I think I should heed them.” He dipped his head slightly, studying me. “Though, Heaven protect me, I think she’s wrong.”

“Oh?”

He stepped back, his lips pursing as his gaze swept me from head to toe and back again.

“Not that I would ever tell her. I learned a long time ago not to contradict a goddess.”

“Now I *have* questions.” I smirked despite myself.

“Later.” He waved it off. “For now, I’ll tell you the only truth that matters and brave the possible wrath of your Munin.”

I rolled my eyes. “Okay. Do tell, my big brave knight.”

He took a breath, then let it out.

“There is nothing here to fix.”

“Nik,” I exhaled, not ready for how much that landed.

“Close your eyes.”

“I might fall off this damn stool if I—”

“Close them.” His voice deepened. He stepped forward again and extended a hand.

I hesitated. Then reached for his hand, letting my eyes fall shut.

“Though I don’t know how this could possibly help.”

“Shhh.” His finger brushed over my lips, silencing the words before they could turn into deflections.

“I could tell you how beautiful you are every day for the next eight hundred years,” he murmured. “And I will, if by some miracle we get that chance.”

His breath warmed the crown of my head.

“Not just this body—this luscious, perfect body,” he went on. “Or those deep brown eyes that could swallow me whole. Or the lips that belong in a Raphael painting, and hair like a descending storm.”

I frowned. “Really laying it on thick, aren’t you?”

But as he spoke, the image flickered into view behind my eyelids. The woman *he* saw when he looked at me.

“But it’s not just your perfect body,” he said. “It’s what’s inside of it that truly floors me. The stunning, raw beauty of your soul—if that’s what it is—whatever force makes you, you. Fierce. Unrelenting. Protective. And somehow, impossibly, gentle in those moments when you think no one’s watching.”

A sound bubbled up from my throat—a hiccup of a laugh. I blinked fast behind closed lids, nearly blinded by the impossible grace of his vision.

“You make me sound like more than just a short, fat serial killer,” I said, the words slipping out before I could filter them. But for the first time, I didn’t really believe them. Not even deep down.

His hand found my jaw. Not tender—*possessive*.

His fingers gripped just hard enough to part my lips. Then one pressed inside.

Pleasure laced with pain, slick and deliberate. I sucked in a breath. The steel of his control, the roughness of his skin—it was too much, yet, not enough.

“Vera.” His hand was at my cheek. “You’ve hardwired me to destroy anything that hurts you.” His thumb slid against my bottom lip. “Don’t make me turn my sights on you.” He paused, voice breaking on the edge of something helpless. “Please don’t make me hurt you again.”

The words weren’t a threat. They were a prayer.

I opened my eyes.

And saw her.

It wasn’t a reflection filtered through his gaze or distorted by Munin’s commentary. Nor was it some softened, self-conscious shadow trying to justify the space she took up. The woman staring back at me, standing tall in steel, silk and blood-red stones, wrapped in a dress that didn’t ask for permission—*she* was all me.

I stepped down from the platform. The skirt moved with me, scratching against my legs like it already knew how I’d walk into war. This wasn’t just fashion. It was a second skin—tailored to my body, not designed to disguise it. And I wore it like a woman who’d stopped apologizing and claimed her damn space.

I ran my fingers down the bodice. Everything I’d once been told to shrink or hide was shaped into something feral and divine. I could tear down gods in this. I could command a room with a glance and silence it with a step. I could take his breath without lifting a hand.

The power didn’t come as a whisper or a hush.

It hit like a spark behind my breastbone, rolling up my spine until it reached my throat. This wasn’t Munin—this wasn’t her sinewy elegance. It was molten electricity, the kind of power that could rupture a world if I let it loose. And it was all mine.

I smiled, wide and real, teeth flashing beneath the rubies’ glamour. Not because I needed validation. But because I finally understood what he saw.

When I turned toward Nikolai, he was watching—silent, reverent, like he’d been waiting centuries for this version of me to arrive.

He didn’t say a word.

He didn’t have to. I already knew.



CHAPTER TEN

The Goddess

MERCER REMAINED ELUSIVE, THOUGH not for lack of effort on my part. I'd flown the grid over the city four times before dusk, eyes sharp as obsidian, tracing his badge number and heartbeat wherever I thought I caught the scent. But he stayed hidden tonight—too many walls, too many bodies in the way.

I liked watching the man when Vera slept safely in the arms of the dragon slayer. Not when they were awake and wrapped around each other. Not when limbs tangled, or teeth grazed skin. No—I stayed for that, silent and still, hoping she'd forget I was there the way she had been doing more often lately.

I wondered if she'd stopped minding. If she'd accept me there during the touches, the moans and the breathless gasps. I hadn't felt so close to anyone in two millennia. Odin had been my first and my last. But this flesh, passion, closeness—I hovered at the edges of it, starved, even though it didn't belong to me.

The gala, at least, was worthy of our efforts. She'd outdone herself. Every detail shimmered with dramatic flair. The black silk tablecloths stitched with silver thread, flower petals that spilled like crimson gemstones across the wooden floors, centerpieces that spiraled up in feather and bone and steel. I caught sight of one iron chandelier, twisted into a raven's wing, and couldn't help but smile.

Clearly, I'd made an impression.

I'd been watching her for an hour.

In that dress.

Empty night, *she wore that dress*.

She moved through the crowd like something summoned. The rubies caught the light like fresh blood, her power brimming beneath the skin like something just barely held in check. That dress hadn't transformed her, but it had showcased what had always been there. Something ancient—older than language, deeper than fate. It was a force Odin had hunted across lifetimes and never managed to cage.

And now, here it was, rooted inside my fiery librarian. I couldn't help but cackle at the irony.

Perhaps, with her, I could finally be free of my twin.

She danced with the dragon slayer while I perched in the rafters above the chandelier, watching the way he looked at her as if she could unmake with a glance. Her smile was hungry. Her confidence undeniable. The way her heels snapped against the floor, the angle of her chin as she introduced the mayor—it was all *divine*.

"Mayor Alvers, it's a pleasure. Thank you for being here, and for your generous support of the library's expansion project."

"Of course," the man said, dazed, gaze lingering too long before he blinked it off. "I'm... honored."

She laughed, gentle but cool, then stepped back as the music changed. She was aware of it now—of what she did to people. I could see it in the way she stood, in the slight smile playing at the corner of her mouth as half the room turned just to watch her speak.

They wouldn't remember her name tomorrow.

Not clearly.

But tonight?

Tonight, they were hers.

Their awe saturated the air, warm and thick against the walls like incense in a cathedral. Some part of them, deep and unspoken, knew to bow. She might have only asked for donations, but they would have bled for her.

I looked closer.

That smirk told me she knew it, too.

Good.

Across the room, I caught motion near the back doors. A flicker of uniform. A flash of familiarity.

I flew higher, moving from rafter to rafter, trying to catch the angle. But guests blocked my view at every turn. Someone stepped sideways or raised a drink. One woman leaned in for a photo. Every time I shifted, someone moved into my line of sight. It was almost deliberate, like he knew I was watching, and was using the crowd to avoid my view.

Impossible.

Only Vera and Nikolai could see me.

Still, I circled lower. Watched as the man turned, the way his arm wrapped around the waist of a woman in black. She was ordinary in every mortal way, but the way he touched her—possessive. Guarded. Something was off with him. This wasn't the Mercer she'd watched over the last three weeks.

Vera and Nikolai stood at the doors, smiling, thanking guests, ushering them out into the night with practiced charm. I drifted down, landed on a candelabra just above them, talons wrapped in iron.

"Glad to see you recovered from yesterday's ordeal." Mercer's voice was calm, pleasant. The arm at his side stayed wrapped around the woman.

"Thank you, Lieutenant." Vera beamed. Her hand slipped into Nikolai's. "We appreciate you stopping by."

He nodded, turned as if to leave. Then paused and looked back.

"Oh, but just so we're clear," he said, still smiling, "you are not to leave town under any circumstances."

"What?" Vera blinked. Confused. "Why not? Nikolai and I were planning a vacation—somewhere quiet, now that the killer's behind bars."

Nikolai stepped forward. "I assume Vera is not a suspect in her own attack. You have her statement. You have the man in custody. She'll be back when it's time to testify."

Mercer didn't flinch. "Correct. She's not a suspect in the most recent attacks. Or even the incident at the candy factory."

Vera narrowed her eyes. "Okay. So what's the problem?"

"You *are* a suspect in at least a dozen unsolved disappearances over the last two years."

Her throat worked once before she choked out a laugh. "You must be joking."

I dropped lower, invisible to them all, landing soft as breath on her shoulder. She didn't startle. Just lifted one hand instinctively, brushing her fingers across the edge of my talon.

Mercer leaned in.

“You can expect an arrest warrant in the morning.” His voice was still smooth. “It took some wrangling to find a judge who wouldn’t tip off your shadow here.” He nodded toward Nikolai. “But I’m confident we’ll have it soon enough.”

“I don’t understand,” she stammered.

Then he *twitched*. His jaw clenched, and his eyes flickered—then flashed *red*.

No.

I flared my wings and shot backward in the air, heart hammering in my hollow bones.

The thing inside Mercer looked up. Not at Vera. Not at Nikolai.

At *me*.

“You can fly, little bird,” he said, voice no longer his own. “But you know who holds the sky.”

Liked what you just read? It's okay. You can admit it. Just between us, you chaotic little murder muffin—you're into this kind of dark, delicious madness.

Episodes 1–4 drop like a full Netflix season on September 8, and if you thought this was unhinged... oh sweet dark goddess, *just wait*. The blood, the spice, the emotional devastation? It's only getting worse. (Better? Worse. Definitely both.)

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You've been warned.

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To the indie authors walking through the fire with me—this book is stitched from the same chaos we bleed into every page. May the gods of caffeine and good algorithms smile upon us.

To my family: thank you for your patience, your support, and for pretending not to notice when I start muttering about cursed men and blood-soaked magic at dinner.

And to the readers: welcome to the dark. I hope you find something in here that ruins you just a little—in the best way.

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Note from the author

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About the author

Kristen is a supply chain professional by day and a warrior by night. When she's not fighting for her life in her toddler's imagination, Kristen trades spreadsheets for storyboards. She enjoys writing worlds steeped in enchantment, ethical enigmas, and diversity, where the allure of darkness is just a heartbeat away from the mundane.

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